

SHRUBS

Star performers, shrubs form the backbone of many garden designs. They can be used together in shrub borders or with other plant groups in mixed displays. Providing color and interest with their foliage, flowers and fruits, many also offer scented blooms and colorful stems.

SIZE CATEGORIES USED WITHIN THIS GROUP

Large over 10ft (3m)	Medium 5–10ft (1.5–3m)	Small up to 5ft (1.5m)
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ABOVE Spring color

The flowering stems of *Exochorda x macrantha* 'The Bride' arch gracefully above forget-me-nots (*Myosotis sylvatica*), English daisies (*Bellis perennis*) and *Tulipa* 'Couleur Cardinal'.

What are shrubs?

Shrubs are woody-stemmed, deciduous or evergreen plants that branch out at or near ground level. Some can grow to more than 20ft (6m) in height, although most attain less than half this size. Leaves come in many forms, from large and glossy to gray and needlelike. There is sometimes an overlap between shrubs and trees because larger shrubs, such as flowering dogwoods (*Cornus* species), can be grown on a single stem. Subshrubs are another anomaly, with woody stems at the base, but softer top growth that may die back over winter in colder regions like a perennial. Examples include ceratostigmas and fuchsias.

Choosing shrubs

When selecting shrubs, focus on those whose needs match your garden conditions. In general, shrubs with large, dark green leaves require shade; plants with gray foliage, such as lavender, require sun; and shrubs with colorful leaves need full sun or partial shade. Also consider the shrub's size and site it where it has space to mature, unless you are planning a topiary display.

Designing with shrubs

When creating a shrub display, try to combine plants with different shapes, habits, flower seasons, and foliage forms and patterns to create a visually balanced scheme and year-round interest. Knit them together in a shrub bed, or use them to provide a backdrop to more transient displays of bulbs, perennials, and annuals in a mixed border.

The shape and habit of shrubs provides a design with structure and form. Contrast low, spreading, prostrate or mat-forming shrubs, such as *Juniperus procumbens* and *Cotoneaster horizontalis*, with more upright forms, such as *Rosmarinus officinalis* 'Miss Jessopp's Upright', and the rounded shapes of bushy shrubs like hebes, skimmias, or boxwood topiary. Mix in shrubs with tiered branch structures, such as *Viburnum plicatum* 'Mariesii', which provide strong horizontal lines in a scheme. Graceful, arching shrubs, such as *Kolkwitzia amabilis*, *Buddleja alternifolia* and *Genista tenera* 'Golden Shower' add an elegant note.

A wide range of shrubs are suitable for creating hedges, enclosures, or screens.

RENOVATING A SHRUB

When evergreens such as mahonias have outgrown their allotted space, many can be cut back hard from midwinter to early spring after flowering. The plant may not flower for two years after such drastic pruning, but its overall

appearance will be much improved. Other shrubs that respond well to this form of renovation include buddlejas, forsythias, kerrias, and smoke trees (*Cotinus*). Some, such as rosemary and lavender, do not.



1 Remove tall stems

Remove all dead and diseased wood, taking it back to healthy growth. Then prune back tall stems, removing them a little at a time so that they do not tear at the base. At this stage, cut the stems to about 2ft (60cm) high, keeping in mind the plant's balanced shape as you prune.



2 Make final pruning cuts

Prune out any remaining crossing stems. Once you have cut back the tall growths, check where you can make your final pruning cuts. Cut out the old growths completely to leave five or six strong young stems.



3 Cut back remaining stems

Cut back the young healthy stems that are left, so that they are 12–16in (30–40cm) above the ground. The final cuts should be at an angle so rainwater can run off. Later in the year, a mass of young shoots will appear along these stems (see left).